Volunteers Wanted: Play Hide-and-Seek With the TSA's Sniffer Dogs

From: Popular Science Mined: 2026-11-12 5 min read

Want to play hide-and-seek with a dog at the airport and help keep travellers safe? The Transportation Security Administration, or TSA, is looking for volunteers to do just that.

The volunteers act as **decoys** for the TSA's explosive detection dogs. In the TSA's words, they play a '**covert** role player' a pretend passenger who carries a '**training item**' while wandering through the airport. You might wait in the ticketing lobby, go through security, or sit near a gate as if you were waiting for a flight. Then the dog team gets to work, trying to sniff you out.

The TSA says a shift 'may feel like a **high-stakes** game of hide and seek.' It is a game with a serious purpose: the training is an important part of keeping the dog teams ready for duty. The whole set-up is meant to copy what the dogs might face in the real world, so they are sharp when it matters.

A volunteer shift takes about two to three hours. You need to be at least 18 years old to sign up on your own, although younger volunteers can take part alongside an adult **companion**, in limited ways. You also need to be comfortable sitting, walking and moving around an airport and wheelchair and scooter users can take part in the programme too.

If you love dogs, there is an extra treat in store. The TSA's annual calendar will be available in December, and it features the agency's working dogs. This year's star is Bolt, a German shorthaired pointer who won the TSA's Cutest Canine Contest for 2026. Bolt will be one of the dogs pictured on the 2027 calendar.

So if you have a free afternoon and a love of dogs, this might be the volunteer job for you.

Word Treasure

decoys -- People or things used to draw attention away from the real thing.
covert -- Secret or hidden, done so that other people do not notice.
high-stakes -- When a lot depends on the result, so it feels very important.
training item -- An object used in practice so the dogs can learn to find it.
companion -- A person who goes along with someone else, often an adult with a child.

Background you need

The TSA is the agency that keeps air travel in the United States safe, and its officers check passengers and bags at airports.

Some of its working dogs are trained to sniff out explosives, and they need regular practice to stay good at their job.

In training, volunteers pretend to be ordinary passengers so the dogs can practise finding them in real airport places like lobbies and gates.

The dogs work in teams with their handlers, and the practice helps the teams stay ready for real duty.

Break it down

LEAD: The TSA is looking for volunteers to play hide-and-seek with its sniffer dogs at the airport.

KEY EVENT: Volunteers act as decoys, or covert role players, carrying a training item while the dog teams try to sniff them out.

+- WHO: Volunteers and the TSA's explosive detection dogs.

+- WHERE: In airport ticketing lobbies, security lines, and near gates.

+- WHEN: A shift takes about two to three hours.

EVIDENCE: The TSA says a shift may feel like a high-stakes game of hide and seek, and the training keeps the dogs sharp for real duty.

OPEN QUESTION: Will enough dog lovers sign up to keep the dog teams well practised?

EXTRA: The TSA's yearly calendar comes out in December, and this year's star is Bolt, winner of the Cutest Canine Contest for 2026.

Why it matters

Sniffer dogs help keep airports safe for everyone who flies, and the training shows how volunteers and working animals can work together to protect travellers.

Test what you remember

1. What do the volunteers pretend to be?

(A) Airport security officers
(B) Passengers carrying a training item
(C) Airline pilots
(D) Dog trainers

2. How long does a volunteer shift take?

(A) About two to three hours
(B) About 30 minutes
(C) About five hours
(D) All day

3. How old must you be to sign up on your own?

(A) At least 18 years old
(B) At least 16 years old
(C) At least 12 years old
(D) At least 21 years old

4. What is this year's star dog of the TSA calendar called?

(A) Bolt
(B) Rex
(C) Max
(D) Buddy

5. What kind of dog is Bolt?

(A) A border collie
(B) A golden retriever
(C) A German shorthaired pointer
(D) A beagle

6. Why does the TSA run this training?

(A) To entertain travellers
(B) To train new pilots
(C) To keep the dog teams ready for duty
(D) To find lost luggage

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: A 4: A 5: C 6: C

Questions to think about

1. The TSA: It says the training is an important part of keeping the dog teams ready for duty.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):